Jack's PDF

Product requirements document

IMPLEMENTED BASELINE / VERSION 1.7 / OCTOBER 12, 2026

A private, minimalist Mac app for reading one PDF at a time, moving easily through a folder, and saving rotated copies while protecting the source.

Product owner / creator	Nikhil Sharma
Implementation	Native Swift, AppKit and PDFKit
Platform	macOS 14 or later; current release binary for Apple silicon
Document status	As-built specification for the first public source release
Licence	MIT
Development credit	Created with OpenAI ChatGPT models

Product intent

Make everyday PDF reading calm and predictable: fit the page to the available width, keep controls compact, make the active page explicit, and avoid accidental edits or overwrites. The app is a personal utility being released as open source.

Primary user and jobs

- A Mac user who wants to open and read a PDF quickly, without an editing workspace.
- A user reviewing several PDFs in a folder with the arrow keys.
- A user correcting page orientation and exporting a separate rotated copy.

Scope boundary

The only document modification is page rotation followed by Save As. Printing, sharing, cloud uploads, form filling, annotations, text editing, tabs, multiple document windows and a thumbnail sidebar are outside the product scope.

This document describes the shipped behaviour, not every earlier design proposal. Acceptance evidence and known limits are separated on page 8.

PRODUCT REQUIREMENTS / 02

Opening and reading

One running app instance, one reader window and one active PDF. A new successful open replaces the current document.

ID	Requirement / acceptance behaviour
R01	Open through Finder, the empty reader, File → Open PDF, or File → Open Recent. Reuse the existing app and window. Accept one PDF per open request.
R02	Start explicit opens in Fit mode. Preserve the selected zoom mode when using Left / Right to move between neighbouring PDFs. Never reflow text or change PDF text placement.
R03	Show pages continuously in a vertical scrolling view, with subtle separation. Up / Down scroll toward earlier / later content. No page-preview pane.
R04	Click visible paper to make that page active, even when several pages fit on screen at low zoom. Do not move the viewport or change zoom. Show a thin accent outline; Page x of y, Fit and Rotate follow that page.
R05	Actual scrolling resumes normal page tracking. Clicking empty canvas preserves the chosen page. Explicit focus survives zoom and rotation.
R06	Left / Right open the previous / next PDF in the current folder. Stop at the first and last entries; do not wrap. Use natural filename order, so 2.pdf precedes 10.pdf.
R07	Count visible, readable, regular .pdf files directly in the selected folder. Ignore case in the extension; exclude hidden files, symbolic links, packages and subfolders.
R08	Request only the containing folder for counting and neighbour navigation. Remember granted read-only access locally. If access is absent, provide Browse folder… without preventing the current PDF from being read.

Read-only interaction

Permit text selection and copying when the PDF allows it. Suppress form editing, annotation editing, embedded document actions, activated links, printing and PDF-content context menus. Existing form values remain visible.

Failed or cancelled opens

Keep the current PDF and any unsaved rotations until another PDF loads successfully. A password prompt, cancelled file picker or failed load must not silently close the current document.

PRODUCT REQUIREMENTS / 03

Interface and menus

Dark, compact and consistent. All app-owned text uses 13-point Avenir; PDF page typography and native macOS panels keep their own presentation.

Header and window

• Title bar: close and minimize buttons, a small colourful app icon, then Jack's PDF. Hide the green window button.

• Document header: filename; then right-aligned file size, folder position (PDF x of y) and page position (Page x of y), separated by bold bullets. Keep metadata anchors stable while navigating within a folder.

• Below the filename, show the containing folder path only. Long names and paths use the available space and allow horizontal scrolling; tooltips reveal the full text.

• Controls: split Rotate button, Fit, minus, zoom slider, plus; labels read Min. 20%, current percentage and Max. 200%. Fit text stays centred.

• Outside full screen, use a 16:10 window with space around it and a minimum size of 800 × 500 points. Reflow the header at narrower widths without shrinking its text.

Final menu structure

Menu	Available commands
Jack's PDF	About Jack's PDF; Quit Jack's PDF
File	Open PDF…; Open Recent; Save As…; Close PDF
Open Recent	Up to ten filenames; Clear History. Show No Recent PDFs when empty.
View	Full Screen; changes to Exit Full Screen while active.

There is no Window menu and no Hide menu item. Menu commands have no keyboard shortcuts. Reading arrows and standard Return / Escape behaviour in dialogs remain available. Rotate and zoom actions remain available in the header.

Full screen

Use native macOS full screen, temporarily releasing the normal window aspect constraint. Exit restores normal window behaviour. The View menu contains only the relevant full-screen command.

Finder integration

Register as a PDF viewer and supply the colourful PDF document icon. Choosing the default PDF app remains a user-controlled macOS action. Finder page thumbnails and custom file icons can take precedence; the app does not change Finder preview preferences.

PRODUCT REQUIREMENTS / 04

Zoom, rotation and export

Preserve document structure and protect the original. Rotation is temporary viewing state until a separate copy is exported.

Area	Required behaviour
Fit and manual zoom	Fit the active page to the viewport width. Recalculate on resize and relevant rotation, without changing Fit merely because scrolling selects another page. Manual zoom spans 20-200% in five-percentage-point steps; Fit may exceed those limits.
Rotation control	The main button rotates the active page 90° clockwise. Its dropdown offers Rotate current page and Rotate all pages. Support repeated clicks and full turns.
Animation	Use a smooth 600 ms clockwise transition with subtle perspective and shadow movement. Continue clockwise through complete turns; do not reverse at 270° to 0°. Queue repeated actions and respect Reduce Motion.
Save As	Offer the native save dialog after rotations. Start in the source folder with a suggested new filename. There is no Save command. Reject the original, including equivalent paths and hard links.
Other destinations	Allow replacing another eligible regular file after the normal macOS confirmation. Validate destination, access and source identity; handle failed writes without damaging the source.
Quality	Apply native PDF page orientation. Do not rasterize pages, downsample embedded images or convert them to JPEG during export. Preserve native text/vector content.

Unsaved rotation decisions

Quit or close the app window: ask whether to Save As, Discard or Cancel. Cancelling keeps the document and rotations open.

Switch PDFs or choose Close PDF: do not show that warning. Successful replacement or Close PDF discards temporary rotations; a failed or cancelled replacement preserves them.

Document limitations

Open encrypted PDFs using a password prompt; do not store the password in history. Rotated export of encrypted PDFs is unavailable because preserving protection has not been implemented. PDFKit may reorganize PDF structure or metadata on export. Signature validity and specialised PDF conformance are not guaranteed.

PRODUCT REQUIREMENTS / 05

Recent files and permissions

Keep history useful without requiring broad filesystem access. Remembering a file and retaining permission to reopen it are separate responsibilities.

History contract

• Retain the last ten successfully opened PDFs, newest first and deduplicated by normalized file URL. Reopening moves the file to the top.

• Save the filename/path even if macOS cannot create a persistent permission bookmark. Never silently omit a successfully viewed file for that reason.

• Use read-only, app-scoped security bookmarks where available. Existing saved history migrates without being cleared.

• Resolve saved bookmarks to track moved files where possible, then try the remembered path. Renew the bookmark after successful opening. Do not reorder history on failed attempts.

Condition	User experience / state rule
Saved access works	Open directly with no additional permission prompt.
File missing or access lost	Show Locate File…, Remove from History and Cancel. Keep the current document and rotations intact.
Locate File…	Use the native single-PDF picker to renew access or choose the file at its new location. Replace the existing history entry only after a successful load; deduplicate the destination.
Remove from History	Remove that saved reference only. Do not delete the PDF or close a currently displayed document.
Cancel or failed locating	Preserve the history entry and current document.
Clear History	Remove recent-file references and saved folder bookmarks. Do not delete documents. Active access for an already-open document ends when it is closed.

Folder access stays separate

Opening a recent PDF must not force a new folder grant. Reuse an existing valid folder bookmark if available; otherwise show Browse folder… for optional counting and neighbour navigation. A file permission does not imply access to its entire folder.

History and permission bookmarks remain local. They contain references, not stored PDF contents or passwords. Entries lost by older versions before recording cannot be reconstructed automatically.

PRODUCT REQUIREMENTS / 06

Privacy, safety and performance

Use native macOS capabilities and narrowly scoped access. The product has no account, tracking service, cloud dependency or network entitlement.

Privacy and original-file protection

• Enable App Sandbox and the hardened runtime. Use standard Open/Save pickers and app-scoped read-only bookmarks. Do not request Full Disk Access, Contacts, Photos, camera or microphone permissions.

• Keep at most ten recent file references and up to ten folder bookmarks in local preferences. Keep document passwords only in process memory when needed.

• Read from a private file-backed snapshot so rendering and export stay consistent if the source changes. Use owner-only permissions for temporary directories and PDF files.

• Never export to the original file, including alternate paths, symbolic-link aliases and hard links. Recheck source/destination identities and validate the finished export before placement.

• Remove released snapshots and failed export temporaries. Clean abandoned snapshots on a subsequent load while preserving active ones. This is ordinary cleanup, not secure erasure.

Implementation and performance requirements

Component	Approach / intent
Rendering and UI	Native Swift, AppKit, PDFKit and Core Animation. No Rust or third-party runtime is required. PDFKit renders file-backed pages on demand.
Large-file loading	Prefer APFS copy-on-write snapshots. On unsupported filesystems, copy in the background with a 1 MiB buffer instead of loading the entire PDF into RAM.
Responsiveness	Keep long file preparation away from the main UI thread. Keep rotation snapshots bounded and release temporary animation resources.
Quality and scope	Optimise for interactive reading and smooth scrolling. Do not claim a universal memory, opening-time or frame-rate target without representative benchmarks.

Public-release privacy

Publish source, generated-test code, documentation and intended artwork only. Exclude private PDFs, local history/bookmarks, machine paths, credentials and signing identities. Use GitHub's no-reply commit address. Strip camera/editing metadata from the public Jack photo while preserving its decoded pixels.

PRODUCT REQUIREMENTS / 07

About and key messages

Maintain the same compact typography and clear recovery choices throughout the app. Native system dialogs retain macOS wording and presentation.

About content order

Centred app icon → text divider → Jack's PDF → divider → short description → divider → instructions → divider → creator/model/date/version credits → divider → memorial → photograph.

Use a nonresizable panel with no scrolling. Compact vertical gaps and a 48-point icon keep all contents visible. The original photograph appears proportionally in a small, centred rounded frame; its display is 128 × 96 points.

Content	Required text
Description	A private, minimal PDF viewer for Mac.
Instructions	Click a page to make it active ↑ / ↓ Scroll up / down ← / → Previous / next PDF in this folder
Credits	Created by Nikhil Sharma Made with OpenAI ChatGPT models. Last updated: October 12, 2026 Version 1.7
Memorial	In loving memory of Jack, our sweetest companion and forever friend. You are still in our hearts and our lives every day.

Important messages and decisions

Original-file protection: "To prevent accidental overwriting, original PDF is always protected. Choose a different filename."

Recent-file recovery: "Locate this recent PDF?" Explain that the file may have moved, be unavailable, or need permission again. Offer Locate File…, Remove from History and Cancel.

Closing with rotations: "Keep your page rotations?" Explain that the original has not changed and a rotated copy can be saved before closing. Offer Cancel, Discard and Save As….

Errors: explain unreadable/empty PDFs, password failures, inaccessible files, invalid destinations and failed saves without losing the current document. Disable document controls when no PDF is open or work is in progress.

The accompanying app-text review is the detailed wording inventory. Dynamic filenames, counts and native macOS/provider messages are not fixed product copy.

PRODUCT REQUIREMENTS / 08

Acceptance and release

Version 1.7 is the implemented baseline. This PRD records tested behaviour and explicit limits; it does not convert spot checks into performance guarantees.

Acceptance area	Evidence and boundary
Opening / navigation	Live checks verified Finder/in-app opening, single-instance reuse, natural folder navigation, and continuous reading of a generated 500-page PDF.
Zoom / focus / rotation	Native reader checks covered Fit/manual zoom, active-page selection, repeated clockwise turns, rapid-click queuing, layout stability and blocked editing/printing paths.
Original and output fidelity	DocumentSupport checks passed original/path/link protection, native text and existing form content, unchanged decoded scanned-image pixels, encrypted-export refusal and snapshot cleanup.
Recent history (1.7)	Automated checks passed metadata-only persistence, ten-entry limits, legacy migration, invalid bookmark fallback, deduplication, removal and clearing. Isolated live checks passed Locate/Cancel/Remove and preservation of unsaved rotations.
Menus / full screen (1.7)	Live checks confirmed no Window menu, one View command, and native full-screen entry and exit. Existing recent entries survived the update and reopened.
Validation limits	No universal performance benchmark, full accessibility certification, notarization, digital-signature preservation claim or comprehensive test of every PDF producer. macOS 14 is the deployment target, not a claim of tests on every supported OS.

Public release

Repository: github.com/nikhilrsharma/jacks-pdf
Release baseline: 1.7 · Creator: Nikhil Sharma · Licence: MIT

Provide readable source, build/test instructions, privacy notes, this PRD and a versioned release. The supplied binary is an Apple-silicon build with local ad-hoc signing, not a Developer ID-notarized distribution. Users can build from source with Xcode; an Intel build is not validated by the current binary checks.

Source of truth and future changes

Baseline reviewed against Sources/App.swift, ReaderPDFView.swift, ZoomControl.swift, ReaderDialog.swift, DocumentSupport.swift, Info.plist, Viewer.entitlements, README.md, SECURITY.md, test sources and VALIDATION.md. All are repository-relative references; no private user documents were used in this PRD.

Future work requires a separate product decision. Search, printing, sharing, editing, tabs, automatic updates and cloud sync are not implied by this release.